

TRAIL BLAZERS

At the India Today Tourism Survey & Awards 2026, states revealed plans to diversify attractions and unlock new destinations

By DHAVAL S. KULKARNI

As domestic travel surges and states compete to attract visitors, India's tourism sector is entering a new phase—one that seeks to balance growth with sustainability, diversify destinations and move beyond traditional tourism circuits. These themes dominated discussions at the India Today Tourism Survey & Awards 2026, held on June 14 and 15 in Goa, where policymakers, administrators and industry stakeholders outlined their vision for the future of Indian tourism.

In his keynote address, Union minister of culture and tourism Gajendra Singh Shekhawat said states have been asked to develop 50 new iconic tourist destinations that meet global standards. This will help decongest India's most-visited destinations. "We have started working proactively with state governments to establish destination management authorities to holistically address issues and challenges," he said.

Photographs by **CHANDRADEEP KUMAR**